

1.8 What Encon Pharma actually does

i This section is about understanding what pharmacists actually do. You will be creating systems for them, so it is important you know what pharmacies and your own company actually do, because if you don't understand what day-to-day work looks like, then there is a risk of you building the wrong thing.

Learning objectives

What is a community pharmacy, and how does one earn money?

They are the local pharmacists who give pills over the counter. These are the customers.

What is NMS (the New Medicine Service), and why does a pharmacy care about it?

NMS is an NHS service where a pharmacist supports a patient who is taking medication. They will call them up and ask questions in a follow-up conversation after a set period of time has passed, for certain long-term medical conditions. Pharmacies care about this because, for each call the pharmacy completes, they will be paid for each completed service. Helping pharmacies deliver more of these, properly, is where our platform started.

What does our platform do for a pharmacy that they couldn't do without it?

The calls would be logged on paper, and the questions being asked would have to be manually written down. Pharmacists wouldn't know which call to take; they would have to check back through massive files. Overall, this process was tedious, long and prone to error.

This is where Encon software comes in: it gets all the calls that need to take place and sorts them into a calendar, so pharmacists know who to call, allowing more calls to be taken in a day. It also offers the questions in the form of tick boxes, allowing them to be easily checked off for whether they do or don't have issues. Overall, making this NMS process quicker and more efficient for the companies.

Who are the actual users — pharmacist, technician, head office — and what does each of them want?

Head office = The central team at a multi-branch pharmacy group. They want oversight across all their branches; the branch staff want to get through today.

WANT: Most likely, they will want to keep costs low and expand their branches of pharmacies.

Technician = These, I believe, are us: people who write and manage the software for these companies to use.

WANT: Most likely, they will want the features they have developed to work.

Pharmacist = A high-street pharmacy. They dispense prescriptions and deliver NHS-funded services. These are our customers.

WANT: Most likely, they want an easier time at work, whether that's with work-related tasks or the systems they use.

What do we mean by an organisation versus a branch?

An organisation is the pharmacy business or group. A branch is one individual pharmacy shop. A group can have anywhere from one branch to hundreds, and this distinction runs right through our data model — get it clear early. Your project uses it too.

What compliance records is a pharmacy legally required to keep, and why is replacing the paper versions worth paying for? Your own project is one of them.

Found online: Key mandatory logs include the Responsible Pharmacist record (kept for 5 years), Controlled Drugs registers (kept for 2 years from the last entry), and standard prescription/dispensing records (kept for at least 2 years).

They are worth paying for because replacing paper versions with digital records means that paper copies of files are less prone to being lost, damaged or stolen. As they are a legal requirement, losing them could lead to huge fines for the company and a massive loss of reputation among customers. As a result, it is worthwhile for the company to invest in replacing the outdated method of logging prescriptions.

Why does this fit in with my Cold Chain Log project?

Task

- Book 30–45 minutes with your manager or someone on the product side and ask them to talk you through it.

I did this with Shamlia on the first day. She talked me through what the company does, what services Encon Pharmacy offers, the company rules, and how Awaies found the gap in the market for the company.

⚠ Questions / Queries / Pushback

No worries for this one.